

THREE NEW PATHS TO THE RAM TEMPLE

Budget: ₹**1,000** crore
Deadline: Between March 2023 and December 2023
Status: At various stages of completion

A 67 KM-LONG RING ROAD TO CONNECT AYODHYA WITH OTHER TOWNS

Budget: ₹**500** crore
Deadline: Land acquisition to be completed by January 2023
Status: Work yet to start

LUXURY CRUISE SERVICE ON SARAYU RIVER

Budget: Not revealed
Deadline: End of 2022
Status: Almost ready to operate

FOUR SHOPPING AND PARKING COMPLEXES

Budget: ₹**100** crore
Deadline: December 2023
Status: At different stages of construction



LATA MANGESHKAR SMRITI CHOWK

Budget: ₹**7.9** crore
Deadline: September 2022
Status: Almost completed

THE MOSQUE

Budget: ₹**100** crore
Deadline: Not fixed yet
Status: Land allotted but construction not permitted yet because the fire department has denied an NOC

**All budget figures are tentative*

A CITY ON THE REMAKE

The Ayodhya administration has drawn up a whole blueprint to turn the temple town into god's own city. Not only will it have a new airport, predictably called the Maryada Purushottam Shriram International Airport, but also a whole new satellite town called Navya Ayodhya, three *path*s leading up to the temple, a ring road, a cruise project, a market complex, a new railway station and a bus terminal, in addition to overall beautification.

All the projects are in various stages of completion. The administration is trying to finish a majority of the projects by December 2023, the deadline after which the Ram temple is expected to be opened to the devotees. "All the pending projects will be executed in a time-bound manner," says Nitish Kumar, the district magistrate of Ayodhya. "We have divided the projects into long, medium and short term. For 'Vision Ayodhya', the deadline is 2047. The priority right now is to finish all short-term projects before December 2023."

A sense of purpose permeates the air when you visit Ayodhya these days. The Ayodhya airport will come up on 821 acres of land, of which 797 acres, sources say, has already been acquired. Expected to cost Rs 525 crore, the project will be executed in three phases. The first to come up will be the air strip, expected to be completed by the end of this year, followed by Terminal 1 by March next year. Flight operations are likely to start after this phase is completed.

The second phase is expected to be finished by December 2023, to coincide with the temple being opened for *darshan*. The third and final phase will begin in January 4 and likely to get done by March 2025. The building itself will mirror aspects of the Ram temple and the walls of the lounge area will be decorated with motifs associated with the Ramayana, say officials.

A new railway station is also in the works. Estimated to cost Rs 350 crore, it will boast several passenger-friendly facilities such as two foot overbridges, escalators and six lifts. Construction work has been planned in two phases—the first on the north side and the second on the south. With almost 90 per cent of the work done on the north side, it is expected to be fully functional by the end of this year. Land for the second phase has already been handed over; work will commence from the beginning of next year.

The most ambitious, however, is the 1,500 acre township called Navya or New Ayodhya. Conceived as a vastu-friendly city, it will have the provision for setting up guest houses by different states and also foreign nations. "There will be shopping complexes, parking zones and hotels with three-, four- and five-star facilities," says an official of the district administration. "There is a plan to develop a residential colony as well." The Uttar Pradesh Avas Vikas Parishad is handling the project.

On entering Ayodhya, three new *path*s will lead up to the Ram temple. The first is the Janmabhoomi *path*, which will be 577 metres long and will directly connect Birla Dharamshala in Ayodhya town to the Ram temple. It is expected to be completed by March 2023. Then there will be the Bhakti *path*, which will connect the Hanumangarhi area to the main